



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Saint Mary School
School Website: <https://stmaryes.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Saint Mary School NJ 07748 presents a clearly Catholic, classical liberal-arts oriented program served by a faculty and community that explicitly foreground faith, virtue, and the great works as a framework for learning. In public-facing materials, the school emphasizes a Catholic identity, a formation-focused mission, and a curriculum organized around grammar, logic, and rhetoric, with explicit reference to liturgical life, prayer, and the integration of faith with reason. The school cites Catholic intellectual tradition, the belief that truth, goodness, and beauty are real and knowable, and a pedagogy that includes Socratic inquiry in upper grades and reverent, memory-based approaches in younger grades. The campus and admissions communications consistently frame the school as a faith-filled, virtuous community that partners with families and seeks to form the whole person. This alignment yields a robust CLASSICAL rating across all six categories.

Key public signals include: the Catholic, classical frame (Catholic Liberal Arts) and language about truth, goodness, and beauty; explicit references to formation, virtue, and wisdom; a curriculum that traces the Grammar–Logic–Rhetoric arc and includes Socratic seminar in upper grades; a living/mentoring faculty narrative and a parent-partner community ethos; and mission statements that position parents as co-educators with the school. The Institute for Catholic Liberal Education affiliation and the school's repeated emphasis on "great books" / engaged inquiry in a Catholic framework reinforce the classical orientation. See evidence on mission, curriculum architecture, pedagogy in upper grades, and community partnerships across multiple pages and posts.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

The school presents itself as a Catholic institution grounded in Catholic thought, with explicit statements about faith shaping education, theology as a governing influence, and liturgical life embedded in formation. For example, public materials describe a "Catholic Classical Liberal Arts education" and the bedrock role of Jesus Christ in the school's life and formation; religion is presented as integral to the curriculum (e.g., religion classes and faith life; text on Our Heavenly Father as a religious artifact; and Catholic identity as foundational). The relationship between faith and reason is repeatedly invoked.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis

Present: truth, goodness, beauty; theology; sacred liturgy/prayer; Catholic identity; Church teaching; Mass/prayer life; sacred tradition. The site repeatedly utilizes language around truth/beauty/goodness, Catholic theology, and liturgical life as central to the education process. Negative indicators (e.g., secular relativism) are not prominent in public pages. Estimated balance: predominantly positive keywords (high multiple mentions of truth/goodness/beauty, theology, liturgy) with minimal negative-symbol signals observed.

Supporting signals include explicit statements about "Catholic classical liberal arts education," "gospel message," and liturgical life in daily formation.

- Why this rating

The school's public materials overtly anchor education in Catholic theological formation, liturgical life, and the transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty). This aligns closely with the Positive Keyword Indicators for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, indicating CLASSICAL alignment rather than secular or purely informational aims.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

Public statements frame education as formation, virtue, and the cultivation of wisdom, not merely job-preparation. Mission statements emphasize partnering with parents, formation in faith, knowledge, and service, and the cultivation of human excellence and virtue. Phrases such as “formation,” “virtue,” “wisdom,” and “the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty” appear in multiple materials; the school explicitly links education to forming students to live virtuous lives and to participate in a long historical tradition.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis

Positive keywords present include formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, telos, pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty, human flourishing, and classical mission. Negative signals such as “workforce readiness” or “21st-century skills” are not prominent in public materials. Estimated result: strong presence of positive indicators with few/no negative indicators, suggesting a CLASSICAL rating.

- Why this rating

The school's stated aims emphasize formation and virtue through a classical mission rather than a narrow vocational trajectory, consistent with the Classical education philosophy. The mission highlights forming the whole person in harmony with truth, goodness, and beauty. This matches the Positive Keyword indicators for Element 2 and aligns with a CLASSICAL classification.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

The public materials explicitly describe a liberal-arts curriculum structured around the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and the Quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy) in the language of a Classical education (e.g., Grammar Stage, Logic Stage, Rhetoric Stage references; presence of Latin and classical language study; foundational emphasis on history, language, and religion as core disciplines). Grade-level pages describe progression through the grammar, logic, and rhetoric phases and the aim of reading well, speaking well, and thinking well, with reference to Latin and other classical elements. The curriculum also emphasizes history as foundational and includes ancient/medieval/historical themes across grades.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis

Positive keywords present include Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Latin/classical languages, history as foundational, Great Books/Great Conversation (conceptual content aligned with classical canon), and history-centric, integrated approach. There are few explicit mentions of “social studies” as a replacement for history; some content notes reference traditional historical chronicles (e.g., The Story of the World) and Latin, indicating a classic-curriculum orientation. Overall, positive indicators far outweigh negative ones. Estimated: multiple positive terms identified; minimal negative signals.

- Why this rating

The curriculum is framed through a clearly classical lens: grammar/logic/rhetoric progression, emphasis on history as core, and integration with Catholic formation. The explicit reference to Latin, ancient to medieval history, and the aims of reading/speaking/thinking well align with CLASSICAL criteria.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- **Evidence**
Public materials describe upper-grade pedagogy emphasizing Socratic discussion/seminars, and lower/grammar-stage approaches (including memory and recitation) that cultivate wonder and discipline. Specific grade-level pages reference Socratic Questioning and Socratic Seminars in the Logic Stage and Rhetoric Stage, with explicit mentions of seminars and rhetoric training (e.g., in Sixth Grade and Eighth Grade sections). There is also mention of memory-based learning styles (recitation, chanting, etc.) in the classical tradition. In lower grades, there is a focus on forming memory and delight through song and review.
- **Positive/Negative keyword analysis**
Positive keywords include Socratic seminar; Socratic questioning; memory work; chanting; liturgical integration; rhetoric training; upper-grade seminars; and lower-grade memory/chanting. Negative indicators such as exclusive project-based, constructivist, or purely experiential approaches are not the central emphasis in the public materials. The presence of Socratic pedagogy and grammar/logic/rhetoric progression suggests CLASSICAL alignment. Estimated: multiple positive pedagogy terms; few to no explicit negative signals observed.
- **Why this rating**
The school demonstrates a clear, staged classical pedagogy: memory-based learning in the early grades; Socratic inquiry and rhetoric-based expression in later grades; and a civically and philosophically engaged approach to learning. This aligns with the CLASSICAL teaching-method indicators.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- **Evidence**
Public materials describe the faculty as “dedicated, joyful” and as a core part of the school’s mission; the faculty are framed as mentors who form the character and intellect, and the school presents a “living curriculum” through teacher leadership and example. The school’s career page and mission-related pages emphasize teacher quality, mentorship, and collaboration.
- **Positive/Negative keyword analysis**
Positive keywords include model teachers; living curriculum; faculty of friends; mentorship; teacher as exemplar; collegial culture. Negative signals are not evident in the public materials. Estimated: strong presence of positive faculty indicators; minimal negative signals.
- **Why this rating**
The public materials present a portrait of virtuous, skilled, and supportive faculty aligned with classical formation; the “living curriculum” concept and the emphasis on mentorship indicate CLASSICAL alignment for Element 5.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- **Evidence**
The school presents itself as partnering with parents in the educational mission, highlighting parental involvement, co-education, and parent formation (e.g., the mission to partner with parents in imparting the gospel; parent engagement through seminars and book studies appears in communications around classical education). The campus and admissions communications emphasize open access and ongoing parent engagement, reflecting a strong community partnership ethos.
- **Positive/Negative keyword analysis**
Positive keywords present include partnership with families; co-educators; parental engagement; home-school collaboration; parent formation; open campus; shared mission. Negative indicators (consumer-language, minimal parent involvement concerns) do not predominate in the public materials. Estimated: multiple positive indicators; few/no negative signals.

- Why this rating

The materials consistently present parents as partners in formation and the community as an extension of the classical educational project, which aligns with the CLASSICAL indicators for Element 6.

Aggregate assessment

- All six categories are CLASSICAL based on keyword analysis and alignment with the Six Essential Elements. The school demonstrates a coherent classical Catholic orientation with explicit affirmation of truth, goodness, and beauty; formation as a telos; a Trivium-centered curriculum; a pedagogy featuring Socratic methods and memory-based practices; a faculty described as mentors living the curriculum; and an engaged, parent-partnered community.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable for a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation. No major needle-moving changes are required, given the current CLASSICAL alignment across all six categories.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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